POSITIVITY OF THE QUARTIC SOLUTION OF A HIGHER DISCRETE PAINLEVÉ-TYPE RECURRENCE

ABSTRACT. We prove positivity of the solution of the quartic discrete Painlevé-type recurrence arising from the quantum minimal surface $w_2 = w_1^3$. The initial data are given by a quadratic combination of Bessel functions of orders $\pm\frac{1}{4}$. The proof converts the Bessel amplitude into a positive Laplace integral and introduces two auxiliary quartic source variables. The four residue classes modulo 4 then reduce to a single family of bi-moment matrices. A triangular factorization, followed by Andréief's identity, fixes the strict sign of every relevant principal minor. Consequently all signed orthogonal-polynomial norms are positive, and their consecutive ratios give $v_n(a) > 0$ for every $a > 0$ and $n \geq 0$.

1. INTRODUCTION

Discrete Painlevé-type recurrences occur in matrix regularizations of minimal surfaces and in the recurrence coefficients of orthogonal polynomials. For the quantum minimal surface associated with the holomorphic curve $w_2 = w_1^{d-1}$, Felder and Hoppe [5] constructed an indefinite Hermitian form whose orthogonal-polynomial norm ratios obey

$$V_n + \frac{1}{a^2} \sum_{j=0}^{d-2} \prod_{k=0}^{d-2} V_{n+j-k} = \frac{n+1}{a}.$$

This connects the discrete equation with the operator formulation of quantum minimal surfaces originating in [3]; see also [2] for special solutions in the cubic case.

For $d = 4$, after setting $v_n = V_n/a$ and $\epsilon = a^{-2}$, the recurrence becomes

$$v_n \left(1 + v_{n-1}v_{n-2} + v_{n+1}v_{n-1} + v_{n+2}v_{n+1}\right) = (n+1)\epsilon, \qquad n \geq 0, \tag{1.1}$$

where $v_n = 0$ for $n < 0$. The two initial values are determined by

$$v_0 = -\frac{1}{a}\frac{h'(a)}{h(a)}, \qquad v_1 = -\frac{1}{a}\frac{h''(a)}{h'(a)}, \tag{1.2}$$

with

$$h(a) = \frac{\pi^2 a}{4}\Big[J_{-1/4}\left(\frac{a^2}{4}\right)^2 - \sqrt{2}\, J_{-1/4}\left(\frac{a^2}{4}\right) J_{1/4}\left(\frac{a^2}{4}\right) + J_{1/4}\left(\frac{a^2}{4}\right)^2\Big]. \tag{1.3}$$

Felder and Hoppe proved the required Gram nondegeneracy for $d = 1, 2, 3$ and formulated it as a conjecture for general d [5, Conjecture 3.6 and Theorem 3.7]. The quartic case is the first one not covered by their argument. Their conjecture is phrased for $a \geq 0$. The result below settles the quartic case on the natural absolutely convergent parameter range $a > 0$; the oscillatory endpoint $a = 0$ is not addressed here.

Our result is the following.

2020 *Mathematics Subject Classification.* Primary 34M55; Secondary 33C45, 15B52, 53A10.

Key words and phrases. discrete Painlevé-type recurrence, indefinite orthogonal polynomials, quartic potential, bi-moment determinant, quantum minimal surface.

Theorem 1.1. *For every $a > 0$, the initial values (1.2)–(1.3) extend uniquely by (1.1) to a sequence defined for every $n \geq 0$. This sequence satisfies*

$$v_n(a) > 0 \qquad \text{for every } n \geq 0.$$

The main point is an integral sign mechanism that applies uniformly to all indices. The Bessel expression (1.3) has a positive Laplace representation. Adding independent source variables for z^4 and $\bar{z}^4$ produces four positive integral kernels, one for each residue class modulo 4. Their mixed derivative matrices are reduced by triangular row operations to

$$\left[\int_0^\infty s^p \left(\frac{s^2}{1+s^2}\right)^q \mathrm{d}\mu(s)\right]_{p,q=0}^{k-1}.$$

Both s and $s^2/(1+s^2)$ are strictly increasing. Andréief's identity therefore expresses the determinant as an integral of a product of two Vandermonde determinants with a fixed positive sign. This proves the required sign pattern for every finite block at once. The Andréief–Vandermonde sign argument itself is standard; the new ingredient is the positive source representation that brings all four quartic symmetry blocks into this form.

The paper is organized as follows. Section 2 recalls the quartic Hermitian form and its relation to the recurrence. Section 3 proves the principal-determinant sign lemma. Section 4 derives the four positive kernels and applies the lemma to the four symmetry blocks. Section 5 then identifies the positive norm ratios with the solution of (1.1).

2. The quartic Gram form

Fix $a > 0$ and write

$$\rho_a(z) = \exp\left(-a|z|^2 + \frac{\mathrm{i}}{4}(z^4 + \bar{z}^4)\right). \tag{2.1}$$

The Gaussian factor makes all polynomial moments absolutely convergent. Let $\eta = \mathrm{e}^{\pi\mathrm{i}/4}$. Decompose the polynomial ring into C_4-weight spaces

$$\mathbb{C}[z] = \bigoplus_{r=0}^{3} \mathcal{P}_r, \qquad \mathcal{P}_r = \{f \in \mathbb{C}[z] : f(\mathrm{i}z) = \mathrm{i}^r f(z)\}.$$

For $f \in \mathcal{P}_r$, set

$$(\sigma f)(z) = (-\eta)^{-r} f(\eta z),$$

and extend σ linearly to $\mathbb{C}[z]$. With $\mathrm{d}A = \mathrm{d}(\operatorname{Re} z)\,\mathrm{d}(\operatorname{Im} z)$, define

$$(f, g)_a = \int_{\mathbb{C}} f(z)\overline{\sigma g(z)}\rho_a(z)\,\mathrm{d}A(z). \tag{2.2}$$

This form is Hermitian. Indeed, distinct weight spaces are orthogonal because the density is invariant under $z \mapsto \mathrm{i}z$. For monomials in a common weight space, put

$$M_{pq}^{(r)} = \int_{\mathbb{C}} z^{r+4p}\bar{z}^{r+4q}\rho_a(z)\,\mathrm{d}A(z).$$

Since $\rho_a(\eta z) = \overline{\rho_a(z)}$, the change of variables $z \mapsto \eta z$ gives

$$\overline{M_{qp}^{(r)}} = (-1)^{q-p} M_{pq}^{(r)}.$$

Together with the twist signs below, this shows $(z^{r+4p}, z^{r+4q})_a = \overline{(z^{r+4q}, z^{r+4p})_a}$, and hence proves the assertion by linearity. If $m = r + 4q$, then

$$\sigma z^m = (-\eta)^{-r}\eta^m z^m = (-1)^{r+q} z^m. \tag{2.3}$$

Thus the Gram matrix on $\mathcal{P}_r$, in the ordered monomial basis $z^r, z^{r+4}, \dots$, has entries

$$G^{(r)}_{pq} = (-1)^{r+q} \int_{\mathbb{C}} z^{r+4p} \bar{z}^{r+4q} \rho_a(z)\, \mathrm{d}A(z), \qquad p, q \geq 0. \tag{2.4}$$

Assume temporarily that the leading principal minors in all four blocks are nonzero. Gram–Schmidt then gives monic polynomials $P_n(z) = z^n + \cdots$, and symmetry implies $P_n \in \mathcal{P}_{n \bmod 4}$. Define

$$\tau(\ell) = \begin{cases} -1, & \ell \equiv 3 \pmod 4, \\ 1, & \ell \not\equiv 3 \pmod 4, \end{cases} \qquad \varrho(n) = (-1)^n \prod_{\ell=0}^{n-1} \tau(\ell) = (-1)^{n+\lfloor n/4 \rfloor}. \tag{2.5}$$

The signed norms h_n are fixed by

$$(P_n, P_n)_a = \varrho(n) h_n. \tag{2.6}$$

Section 4 will prove simultaneously that all the required minors are nonzero and that $h_n > 0$.

3. A principal-determinant sign lemma

We isolate the integral argument that drives the proof. Let $y > 0$, $\alpha \geq 0$, and $\beta \geq 0$, and define

$$\Phi_{\alpha,\beta}(w; y) = \int_0^\infty \mathrm{e}^{-ys} s^{\alpha - 1/2} (1 + ws^2)^{-\beta - 1/2}\, \mathrm{d}s, \qquad w > 0. \tag{3.1}$$

For $p, q \geq 0$, put

$$D^{\alpha,\beta}_{pq} = \partial_u^p \partial_v^q \Phi_{\alpha,\beta}(uv; y)\big|_{u=v=1}. \tag{3.2}$$

Lemma 3.1 (principal determinant signs)**.** *For every $k \geq 1$,*

$$\operatorname{sgn} \det \left[D^{\alpha,\beta}_{pq} \right]_{p,q=0}^{k-1} = (-1)^{k(k-1)/2}. \tag{3.3}$$

Proof. Set

$$b = \beta + \frac{1}{2}, \qquad \gamma = \frac{\alpha}{2} + \frac{1}{4}, \qquad L(y) = \Phi_{\alpha,\beta}(1; y).$$

The substitution $t = \sqrt{w}\, s$ in (3.1) gives

$$\Phi_{\alpha,\beta}(w; y) = w^{-\gamma} L\left(\frac{y}{\sqrt{w}} \right). \tag{3.4}$$

Let $\vartheta = w\partial_w$, and use the falling-factorial notation

$$(\vartheta)^{\underline{p}} = \vartheta(\vartheta - 1) \cdots (\vartheta - p + 1).$$

Under (3.4), ϑ acts on L as

$$\mathcal{A} = -\gamma - \frac{y}{2} \partial_y.$$

Since $w = uv$,

$$\partial_u^p \partial_v^q F(uv)\big|_{u=v=1} = (\vartheta)^{\underline{p}} (\vartheta)^{\underline{q}} F(w)\big|_{w=1}.$$

It follows that

$$D^{\alpha,\beta}_{pq} = (\mathcal{A})^{\underline{p}} (\mathcal{A})^{\underline{q}} L(y). \tag{3.5}$$

Define

$$f(s) = \frac{s^2}{1 + s^2}$$

and the bi-moments

$$B_{pq} = \int_0^\infty s^p f(s)^q \mathrm{e}^{-ys} s^{\alpha - 1/2} (1 + s^2)^{-\beta - 1/2}\, \mathrm{d}s. \tag{3.6}$$

Direct differentiation of (3.1) with respect to w gives

$$(\mathcal{A})^{\underline{q}}L(y) = (-1)^q (b)_q B_{0q}, \tag{3.7}$$

where $(b)_q$ is the rising Pochhammer symbol. On the other hand,

$$(\mathcal{A})^{\underline{p}} = \sum_{i=0}^{p} c_{pi}(y)\partial_y^i, \qquad c_{pp}(y) = \left(-\frac{y}{2}\right)^p. \tag{3.8}$$

Since $\partial_y^i B_{0q} = (-1)^i B_{iq}$, (3.5)–(3.8) give a factorization

$$D = RBC, \tag{3.9}$$

for the $k \times k$ truncations of D and B, where R is lower triangular with diagonal

$$R_{pp} = \left(\frac{y}{2}\right)^p > 0,$$

and C is diagonal with

$$C_{qq} = (-1)^q (b)_q.$$

It remains to determine the sign of $\det B$. Andréief's integration identity [1, 6] gives

$$\begin{aligned} \det[B_{pq}]_{p,q=0}^{k-1} = \frac{1}{k!} \int_{(0,\infty)^k} & \det[s_j^p]_{p=0,\dots,k-1}^{j=1,\dots,k} \\ & \times \det[f(s_j)^q]_{q=0,\dots,k-1}^{j=1,\dots,k} \prod_{j=1}^{k} \mathrm{d}\mu(s_j), \end{aligned} \tag{3.10}$$

where

$$\mathrm{d}\mu(s) = \mathrm{e}^{-ys} s^{\alpha-1/2}(1+s^2)^{-\beta-1/2}\,\mathrm{d}s.$$

The two determinants in (3.10) are Vandermonde determinants. Because both s and $f(s) = s^2/(1+s^2)$ are strictly increasing on $(0,\infty)$, their product is nonnegative and is strictly positive whenever the s_j's are distinct. Hence $\det B > 0$.

The determinant of R is positive, whereas

$$\operatorname{sgn}\det C = (-1)^{0+1+\cdots+(k-1)} = (-1)^{k(k-1)/2}.$$

The factorization (3.9) proves (3.3). □

4. The four positive kernels

We first turn the Bessel initial function into a positive integral. For $x > 0$, the connection formula

$$J_{-1/4}(x) = \frac{J_{1/4}(x) - Y_{1/4}(x)}{\sqrt{2}}$$

reduces (1.3) to

$$h(a) = \frac{\pi^2 a}{8}\left[J_{1/4}\left(\frac{a^2}{4}\right)^2 + Y_{1/4}\left(\frac{a^2}{4}\right)^2\right]. \tag{4.1}$$

The Dixon–Ferrar formula [4] (see also [7, formula 6.518]) states that, for $x > 0$ and $|\operatorname{Re}\nu| < \frac{1}{2}$,

$$J_\nu(x)^2 + Y_\nu(x)^2 = \frac{8\cos(\pi\nu)}{\pi^2}\int_0^\infty K_{2\nu}(2x\sinh t)\,\mathrm{d}t. \tag{4.2}$$

Using

$$K_{1/2}(u) = \sqrt{\frac{\pi}{2u}}\mathrm{e}^{-u}$$

in (4.1), and then setting $s = \sinh t$, gives

$$h(a) = \sqrt{\frac{\pi}{2}} \int_0^\infty \frac{\mathrm{e}^{-a^2 s/2}}{\sqrt{s(1+s^2)}}\,\mathrm{d}s. \tag{4.3}$$

Set

$$y = \frac{a^2}{2}, \qquad C = \sqrt{\frac{\pi}{2}}.$$

We now introduce an angular source. For $u, v > 0$, define the radial generating function

$$\mathcal{Z}(a; u, v) = \pi \int_0^\infty \mathrm{e}^{-at} J_0\left(\frac{t^2\sqrt{uv}}{2}\right)\,\mathrm{d}t. \tag{4.4}$$

This is the angularly integrated two-source expression. It is not being defined as a two-dimensional integral away from $u = v$; such an integral need not be absolutely convergent. For each fixed R, however, termwise angular integration is legitimate and gives

$$\int_0^{2\pi} \exp\left(\frac{\mathrm{i}R^4}{4}(u\mathrm{e}^{4\mathrm{i}\theta} + v\mathrm{e}^{-4\mathrm{i}\theta})\right)\,\mathrm{d}\theta = 2\pi J_0\left(\frac{R^4\sqrt{uv}}{2}\right), \tag{4.5}$$

and $t = R^2$ gives (4.4). On compact subsets of $(0,\infty)^2$, every u, v-derivative of the Bessel integrand is bounded by e^{-at} times a polynomial in t. Thus derivatives may be passed under the t-integral. The precise comparison with the planar moments is recorded in Lemma 4.1 below.

We next record explicitly the normalization connecting this source to the prescribed initial function. Polar coordinates and (4.5) give

$$\int_{\mathbb{C}} \rho_a(z)\,\mathrm{d}A(z) = \pi \int_0^\infty \mathrm{e}^{-at} J_0\left(\frac{t^2}{2}\right)\,\mathrm{d}t = \mathcal{Z}(a; 1, 1). \tag{4.6}$$

The evaluation of this Laplace transform is the $d = 4$ case of [5, Proposition 4.1], and is exactly the Bessel combination (1.3). Thus all three quantities in (4.6) equal $h(a)$; independently, (4.1)–(4.3) give its positive Laplace representation.

Put $w = uv$. The change of variables $t = w^{-1/4}x$ in (4.4), followed by (4.3), now gives

$$\mathcal{Z}(a; u, v) = w^{-1/4} h(aw^{-1/4}),$$

and hence

$$\mathcal{Z}(a; u, v) = C \int_0^\infty \frac{\mathrm{e}^{-ys}}{\sqrt{s(1+uvs^2)}}\,\mathrm{d}s = C\Phi_{0,0}(uv; y). \tag{4.7}$$

For $r = 0, 1, 2, 3$, put

$$\mathcal{Z}_r = (-\partial_a)^r \mathcal{Z}.$$

Lemma 4.1 (source derivatives and planar moments)**.** *For $r \in \{0, 1, 2, 3\}$ and $p, q \geq 0$,*

$$\partial_u^p \partial_v^q \mathcal{Z}_r(a; u, v)|_{u=v=1} = \left(\frac{\mathrm{i}}{4}\right)^{p+q} \int_{\mathbb{C}} z^{r+4p} \bar{z}^{r+4q} \rho_a(z)\,\mathrm{d}A(z). \tag{4.8}$$

Proof. Fix a compact rectangle $Q \subset (0,\infty)^2$ containing $(1, 1)$. Repeated differentiation of the Bessel integrand in (4.4), using the standard derivative recurrences for J_ν, gives, for fixed p, q, r, a bound of the form

$$\left|\partial_u^p \partial_v^q (-\partial_a)^r \left[\mathrm{e}^{-at} J_0\left(\frac{t^2\sqrt{uv}}{2}\right)\right]\right| \leq C_{Q,p,q,r} \mathrm{e}^{-at}(1+t)^{2p+2q+r}.$$

Thus dominated convergence permits all the indicated derivatives to pass through the t-integral.

For $R > 0$, apply the angular identity (4.5) on the disk $|z| \le R$, where all parameter differentiations are over a compact domain. At $u = v = 1$, each u-derivative contributes $\mathrm{i}z^4/4$, each v-derivative contributes $\mathrm{i}\bar{z}^4/4$, and each $-\partial_a$ contributes $|z|^2 = z\bar{z}$. This gives (4.8) with the planar integral restricted to $|z| \le R$. Letting $R \to \infty$ is justified on the planar side by the Gaussian factor times a fixed polynomial, and on the radial side by the preceding bound. This proves the identity. □

Lemma 4.2. *The four radial source functions are*

$$\begin{array}{c|c} r & \mathcal{Z}_r(a;u,v) \\ \hline 0 & C\Phi_{0,0}(uv;y), \\ 1 & aC\Phi_{1,0}(uv;y), \\ 2 & 2C\Phi_{1,1}(uv;y), \\ 3 & 2aC\Phi_{2,1}(uv;y). \end{array} \tag{4.9}$$

Proof. The first two rows follow by differentiating (4.7). For the third row, integration by parts gives

$$\begin{aligned} y\int_0^\infty \frac{\mathrm{e}^{-ys}s^{3/2}}{\sqrt{1+uvs^2}}\,\mathrm{d}s = \frac{1}{2}\int_0^\infty \frac{\mathrm{e}^{-ys}s^{1/2}}{\sqrt{1+uvs^2}}\,\mathrm{d}s \\ + \int_0^\infty \frac{\mathrm{e}^{-ys}s^{1/2}}{(1+uvs^2)^{3/2}}\,\mathrm{d}s. \end{aligned} \tag{4.10}$$

The boundary terms vanish at 0 and ∞. Since

$$(-\partial_a)^2 = \partial_y + 2y\partial_y^2,$$

equation (4.10) gives $\mathcal{Z}_2 = 2C\Phi_{1,1}$. One more differentiation gives $\mathcal{Z}_3 = 2aC\Phi_{2,1}$. □

For $k \ge 1$, set

$$\Delta_k^{(r)} = \det[G_{pq}^{(r)}]_{p,q=0}^{k-1}, \qquad \Delta_0^{(r)} = 1. \tag{4.11}$$

Proposition 4.3. *For every $r \in \{0,1,2,3\}$ and $k \ge 1$,*

$$\operatorname{sgn}\Delta_k^{(r)} = (-1)^{rk+k(k-1)/2}. \tag{4.12}$$

Proof. Let

$$D_{pq}^{(r)} = \partial_u^p \partial_v^q \mathcal{Z}_r(a;u,v)\big|_{u=v=1}.$$

Every scalar multiplier in (4.9) is positive. Lemma 3.1, applied to the four parameter pairs

$$(\alpha,\beta) = (0,0), (1,0), (1,1), (2,1),$$

therefore gives

$$\operatorname{sgn}\det[D_{pq}^{(r)}]_{p,q=0}^{k-1} = (-1)^{k(k-1)/2}. \tag{4.13}$$

Lemma 4.1, combined with (2.4), gives

$$G_{pq}^{(r)} = (-1)^{r+q}\left(\frac{4}{\mathrm{i}}\right)^{p+q} D_{pq}^{(r)}. \tag{4.14}$$

Let $S_k = k(k-1)/2$. Factoring the row and column phases in (4.14) yields

$$\Delta_k^{(r)} = (-1)^{rk} 16^{S_k} \det[D_{pq}^{(r)}]_{p,q=0}^{k-1}. \tag{4.15}$$

Now (4.12) follows from (4.13). □

Corollary 4.4. *For every $N \geq 0$, the leading Gram matrix $\left[(z^p, z^q)_a\right]_{p,q=0}^{N}$ is nondegenerate, and the signed norms in (2.6) satisfy*

$$h_n > 0 \qquad (n \geq 0).$$

Proof. The block sign formula shows first that every $\Delta_k^{(r)}$ is nonzero. After simultaneously permuting rows and columns to group monomials by their residue modulo 4, every finite leading Gram matrix is block diagonal, and its blocks are leading matrices of the four types in (4.11). It is therefore nondegenerate, and all the monic orthogonal polynomials exist. If $n = r + 4j$, Gram–Schmidt within $\mathcal{P}_r$ gives

$$(P_n, P_n)_a = \frac{\Delta_{j+1}^{(r)}}{\Delta_j^{(r)}}. \tag{4.16}$$

Taking the quotient of the signs in (4.12) gives

$$\operatorname{sgn}(P_n, P_n)_a = (-1)^{r+j}.$$

But (2.5) gives $\varrho(r + 4j) = (-1)^{r+j}$. Hence $h_n = \varrho(n)(P_n, P_n)_a > 0$. □

5. Identification with the quartic recurrence

It remains to verify that the positive norm ratios give precisely the sequence in Theorem 1.1. Define

$$V_n = \frac{h_{n+1}}{h_n}, \qquad v_n = \frac{V_n}{a}. \tag{5.1}$$

Corollary 4.4 already gives

$$v_n > 0 \qquad (n \geq 0). \tag{5.2}$$

For clarity, we include the recurrence calculation from the quartic Gram form; it is the specialization of [5, equations (3.1)–(3.3)]. Differentiating (2.1) and integrating by parts in (2.2) give

$$\left((\partial_z + \mathrm{i}z^3)f, g\right)_a = -\tau(\ell)a(f, zg)_a \tag{5.3}$$

when g has C_4-weight ℓ. The Gaussian decay removes the boundary term. We spell out the bandedness consequence, since weight considerations alone do not exclude more distant lower terms. Write $L = \partial_z + \mathrm{i}z^3$. If $j \leq n - 7$ has the same weight as zP_n, then $\deg LP_j \leq j + 3 < n$, and

$$(LP_j, P_n)_a = -\tau(n)a(P_j, zP_n)_a = 0.$$

Hermitian symmetry therefore gives $(zP_n, P_j)_a = 0$. Similarly, if $j \leq n - 5$ has the same weight as LP_n, then

$$(LP_n, P_j)_a = -\tau(j)a(P_n, zP_j)_a = 0,$$

because $\deg(zP_j) < n$. Weight, degree, and orthogonality now give

$$\begin{aligned} zP_n &= P_{n+1} + \frac{\mathrm{i}}{a}\frac{h_n}{h_{n-3}}P_{n-3}, \\ (\partial_z + \mathrm{i}z^3)P_n &= \mathrm{i}P_{n+3} + a\frac{h_n}{h_{n-1}}P_{n-1}, \end{aligned} \tag{5.4}$$

where terms with negative indices are omitted. Pairing the first expansion with P_{n-3}, and using (5.3) with $f = P_{n-3}$, $g = P_n$, determines its lower coefficient. Pairing the second expansion with P_{n-1} determines the other one. In both calculations one uses

$$\varrho(n) = \tau(n)\varrho(n-3), \qquad \varrho(n) = -\tau(n-1)\varrho(n-1).$$

For completeness, if c_n is the coefficient of P_{n-3} in zP_n, then

$$\begin{aligned} \mathrm{i}\varrho(n)h_n &= (LP_{n-3}, P_n)_a = -\tau(n)a(P_{n-3}, zP_n)_a, \\ c_n &= \frac{(zP_n, P_{n-3})_a}{\varrho(n-3)h_{n-3}} = \frac{\mathrm{i}}{a}\frac{h_n}{h_{n-3}}, \end{aligned}$$

where Hermitian symmetry and $\varrho(n) = \tau(n)\varrho(n-3)$ are used in the second line. Similarly, if d_n is the coefficient of P_{n-1} in LP_n, then

$$\begin{aligned} d_n &= \frac{(LP_n, P_{n-1})_a}{\varrho(n-1)h_{n-1}} \\ &= -\tau(n-1)a\frac{(P_n, zP_{n-1})_a}{\varrho(n-1)h_{n-1}} = a\frac{h_n}{h_{n-1}}, \end{aligned}$$

because the leading term of zP_{n-1} is P_n and $\varrho(n) = -\tau(n-1)\varrho(n-1)$. These computations also make the phase cancellation in (5.4) explicit.

The coefficient of P_{n-1} in z^3P_n receives three contributions: the downward step in the first formula of (5.4) may occur after zero, one, or two upward steps. Hence that coefficient is

$$\frac{\mathrm{i}}{a}V_{n-1}\left(V_{n-2}V_{n-3} + V_nV_{n-2} + V_{n+1}V_n\right).$$

Subtracting $\mathrm{i}z^3P_n$ from the second formula in (5.4), and using that the coefficient of P_{n-1} in $\partial_z P_n$ is n, gives

$$V_m\left[1 + \frac{1}{a^2}\left(V_{m-1}V_{m-2} + V_{m+1}V_{m-1} + V_{m+2}V_{m+1}\right)\right] = \frac{m+1}{a}. \tag{5.5}$$

With $V_m = av_m$, this is (1.1).

Finally, $P_0 = 1$, $P_1 = z$, and $P_2 = z^2$. From (4.6), differentiation under the absolutely convergent planar integral gives

$$h'(a) = -\int_{\mathbb{C}} |z|^2\rho_a(z)\,\mathrm{d}A(z), \qquad h''(a) = \int_{\mathbb{C}} |z|^4\rho_a(z)\,\mathrm{d}A(z).$$

The twist signs (2.3) and $\varrho(0) = -\varrho(1) = \varrho(2) = 1$ consequently give

$$h_0 = h, \qquad h_1 = -h', \qquad h_2 = h''.$$

Therefore (5.1) gives exactly (1.2). Conversely, solving (1.1) for its newest term gives

$$v_{m+2} = \frac{(m+1)a^{-2}/v_m - 1 - v_{m-1}v_{m-2} - v_{m+1}v_{m-1}}{v_{m+1}}. \tag{5.6}$$

Thus v_{m+2} is uniquely determined by the preceding terms whenever $v_mv_{m+1} \neq 0$. The norm-ratio sequence (5.1) is positive, so (5.6) applies at every step and constructs a global extension of the prescribed initial data. If $(\widetilde{v}_n)$ is any other extension, then $\widetilde{v}_0 = v_0$ and $\widetilde{v}_1 = v_1$. Assuming $\widetilde{v}_j = v_j$ through $j = m+1$, the positivity of v_mv_{m+1} allows the equation at index m to be solved for its newest term, forcing $\widetilde{v}_{m+2} = v_{m+2}$. Induction proves uniqueness. Together with (5.2), this proves Theorem 1.1.

Remark 5.1. The uniqueness in Theorem 1.1 concerns the sequence with the prescribed initial data. The argument does not claim a classification of positive solutions with other initial data, a closed evaluation of the Gram determinants, asymptotic formulas for v_n, or a result at the endpoint $a = 0$.

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